It was clear that the Israeli representatives at the annual meeting would have to adopt a stance, as the Gaza Strip was in our hands and we were being pressured to return the Strip to Egypt as part of the evacuation from Sinai.

Israel's traditional position was that it was the UN's job to process the plans for the permanent settlement of the refugees, including the Gaza refugees. Israel would make a *full contribution* to these plans, though it refrained from going into detail about what this contribution would be. Now that Israel was under pressure with regard to the Gaza issue, the question arose as to whether it should go into specific details and figures regarding its willingness to absorb refugees and resettle them.

Ben-Gurion wanted his government's opinion and so convened the meeting (though he was absent due to illness). The question presented to the ministers was: Can we authorize our representatives to the General Assembly to interpret the term *full contribution* that we use not only relating to *compensation* but also to *resettlement*?

After a discussion of several hours, and after all the participants had asked their questions and voiced their reservations and views, the government concluded as follows:

We decide:

1. The Israeli government grants power to the UN General Assembly to propose solutions to the refugee problem in Gaza by the United Nations in various ways, including in Israel.
2. (With a majority of six in favor and three against) we decide to inform the delegation alone that Israel would be prepared under Article I to resettle a small number of Gaza refugees (not to exceed 15–20,000) within the borders of Israel. The delegation is not authorized to use this number externally.

Regarding the 15,000 to 20,000 people to be resettled "within the borders of Israel," the intention was actually to settle them in Gaza, an area included in the British Mandate for Palestine, which was conquered by the Egyptian army during the War of Independence and came back under Israeli control during the Sinai Campaign.